

HOME ADVANTAGE

With 13 million subscribers, six players positioning themselves for a slice of the great pie in the sky and an exploding market, the DTH industry expects great growth and fierce competition



HEMANT CHAWLA

■ By Nivedita Mukherjee

It doesn't get bigger than this: a 360-degree marketing campaign, nine top celebrities of India in one flick, brand endorsements by small screen *saas* and *bahus* and the reel-to-real competition of filmdom's two most-wanted Khans playing out in rival advertisements. Or does it? Few are willing to bet on it, given the way India Inc has been raiding its war-chest to capture the market for direct-to-home (DTH) satellite television since it was introduced in July 2006.

Investments worth thousands of crores of rupees are being pumped in by the companies. Reliance Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) will be investing Rs 2,050 crore in the next two years, Videocon plans to put in Rs 1,000 crore in the coming year while Dish TV will pump in Rs 1,600 crore in the next two years. The Tata Sky project cost has gone up to Rs 4,000 crore and Airtel will in-

vest Rs 150 crore in the first phase. Industry experts reckon the advertising budget will go up to anywhere around Rs 700-800 crore in the near future.

The infusion of mega bucks has become imperative with the latest jostling for space between old and new entrants. While there are two major commercial players at the national level—Tata Sky (a Tata Group and Star TV joint venture) and the Subhash Chandra-owned Essel Group-promoted Dish TV—many others have also begun to flex their muscles. Sun Direct, which made its presence felt in the south after its launch in January this year, is finalising plans to scale up operations in the north. Reliance ADAG's BIG TV and Sunil Bharti Mittal's Airtel Digital TV, too, seek to redefine the paradigm.

Add to that the race for market share. While BIG TV is looking at capturing 40 per cent of the new DTH subscribers that are likely to be added in the next 12-18 months, Dish

SCREEN PLAY: A DTH player's staff monitors channels